Enterprise Agents and the Frontier Labs

What enterprises and the frontier labs are doing in AI agents that finish enterprise work, and which budget pays for that work

1. Key takeaways

The theme covers AI agents that finish a defined piece of enterprise work, such as working a denied medical claim or clearing a purchase order exception, and the software that runs them. Enterprises are adopting these agents quickly, while OpenAI, Anthropic, Microsoft and Google are moving from selling models toward selling the agents and the deployment work themselves.

1. **The money for agents that finish work comes from the labor budget, which is several times the software budget and is moving to business owners outside IT**
   - Companies spend far more on the people and outsourcers who do their work than on the software those people use, and every published estimate puts that gap at several times or more. Sequoia estimates that six dollars go to services for every dollar spent on software (Sequoia), Felicis finds labor budgets run 35 times software budgets (Felicis), and US government data counts 17,753,430 office and administrative support workers at a mean wage of $51,560 (BLS).
   - That labor spending is starting to be repriced, as agents take over part of the work that outsourcers bill for by the hour or by the head. HFS expects agent-delivered services to become a $422 billion segment inside the outsourcing market by 2035 (HFS Research), and a contact center outsourcing executive says agents are moving his industry's billing from a price per worker to a price per use (expert call).
   - The person who signs for this spend increasingly sits in the business and compares an agent with the outsourcer's invoice rather than with another software license. BCG finds that more than 80% of AI spending now sits outside enterprise IT (BCG), and Sequoia points out that moving an outsourcing contract to an AI provider is a simple change of vendor, while cutting headcount means reorganizing the company (Sequoia).
2. **Almost every big enterprise now runs agents, but few can show a return yet, and buyers still pay for AI mostly by the seat or by usage**
   - Agent use has spread across big companies quickly, and on Microsoft's platform alone the number of agents grew by more than 30% in a single quarter. In a July 2026 survey 95.3% of enterprises ran at least one agent workflow in production (IDC), and Microsoft counts over 50M agents in its registry, up more than 30% in a quarter (Microsoft earnings call).
   - The value has not kept pace with the usage, because most agents still do simple, narrow tasks that are hard to tie to a line in the budget. Only 13% of CIOs report significant or transformational value from AI (Gartner), only 22% of organizations have scaled AI across multiple business units (Gartner), and the head of Amazon Web Services describes most enterprise agents as relatively simple and mostly non-autonomous (AWS interview).
   - Buyers therefore stay wary of savings claims and keep paying the way they always have. For AI features billed separately, decision makers still rank per-seat pricing first at 42.3%, ahead of consumption at 36.6% and outcome pricing at 21.1% (Futurum), ServiceNow's finance chief says its customers are not asking for outcome pricing at all (ServiceNow earnings call), and a revenue cycle executive whose own gains are in the low double digits dismisses any vendor claim above that (expert call).
3. **Since January the labs have moved from selling models to selling the agent runtime, ready-made department agents and their own deployment services**
   - The software that runs agents, which agent platforms used to sell, now comes from the labs at close to the cost of the tokens it uses. Anthropic launched Managed Agents at $0.08 per session-hour in April

(Anthropic), and OpenAI opened its Agents API in September with no fees beyond tokens and tools (OpenAI).

- Both labs also ship ready-made agents for whole departments that take a goal through to finished documents and analyses. Anthropic open-sourced 11 Cowork plugins for roles from sales and finance to legal and customer support in January (Anthropic), and OpenAI launched ChatGPT Work in July as an agent that turns a goal into finished work (OpenAI).
- To get those agents into production the labs are adding people as well as products, and they are only now building the services arms that reach the labor budget. OpenAI formed a majority-owned deployment company with more than $4B of initial investment (OpenAI), Anthropic formed a services firm with Blackstone, Hellman & Friedman and Goldman Sachs aimed at mid-sized companies (Anthropic), and OpenAI's Frontier Alliances bring in BCG, McKinsey, Accenture and Capgemini to deploy its platform (OpenAI). The labs are also buying, as AI companies funded by venture investors bought 195 other AI companies through September 29, with OpenAI making 10 of those deals and Anthropic 5 (Crunchbase via Forbes).
- Big buyers are hedging against any single lab by spreading their bets across models and keeping control of their own agents. In a survey 81% of big-company CIOs use three or more model families (a16z CIO survey), and 67% of agent platform users expect the control plane to sit at least partly outside a provider-managed service (VentureBeat survey).

4. **The labs ship templates and tools but leave the work that needs private data, write access to core systems, a license or liability with the buyer and its service providers**
   - Lab products stop at the template and leave the buyer responsible for the outcome, because running a regulated or messy operation is slow, local and risky work. Sapphire Ventures finds that the labs do not want to take on the operational mess of running work for customers (Sapphire Ventures), and Andrej Karpathy points builders to work that is valuable and easy to check but undertrained by the frontier labs (conference summary).
   - Whoever does the work also keeps the data from doing it, which makes each new job cheaper to deliver and harder for a rival to copy. Bessemer argues that each delivered unit of verifiable work becomes training data for the company that delivers it (Bessemer), and Menlo Ventures finds that regulatory certification and human sign-off slow competitors down (Menlo Ventures).
   - How far the labs reach into the work itself differs sharply from one industry to the next. In health plan administration, insurance below the biggest carriers, and procurement and freight, the labs have shipped tools while the accountable work still sits with plans, carriers, claims administrators and purchasing teams. In bank compliance, life sciences research and finance operations the labs now sell the core tool through core banking providers, direct deals with drug companies and consulting partners, and in legal services and customer service the labs and the big software suites sell the agents and the finished work directly.

2. Interesting categories

We split the theme into horizontal software that runs agents across a company, regulated verticals where a license or rulebook governs the work, and non-regulated verticals where the work is operational. Each category summarizes what enterprises and the labs are doing there, with the lab moves dated from January 2026 onward.

A. Horizontal

A1. Orchestration and Execution Platforms

What is happening:

- **Companies are handing agents real authority faster than they build the controls to govern them.** In a BCG survey of 1,330 executives, 42% expect agents to hold real decision authority by 2030 while only 5% have the controls in place (BCG).

- **Custom agent systems built by outside engineers rarely last, because they cost too much to maintain.** Gartner expects 70% of enterprises to abandon agent systems built by vendor engineering teams by 2028 because of maintenance costs (Gartner).
- **Every lab and cloud now ships the generic runtime and control plane for agents.** OpenAI launched Frontier in February with HP, Oracle, State Farm, Thermo Fisher and Uber as first adopters (OpenAI), Google turned Vertex AI into the Gemini Enterprise Agent Platform in April (Google), and Microsoft sells Agent 365 to govern agents at $15 per user per month (Microsoft).

Example companies: Duvo, Sycamore

A2. Work Context

What is happening:

- **Enterprises expect to tailor agents to how their own business works, which needs context that no model ships with.** In a Deloitte survey of 3,235 leaders, 85% expect to customize agents to fit the unique needs of their business (Deloitte).
- **The big application suites are buying context about how work gets done and keeping it inside their own products.** SAP agreed to buy a work context graph company for its HR suite (SAP).
- **The labs now bundle company context into their own platforms at no extra charge.** Frontier includes a business context layer that spans warehouses, CRM, ticketing and internal apps (OpenAI), and Anthropic lets admins package skills and connectors into private plugins for each team (Anthropic).

Example companies: Edra, Workfabric AI

B. Regulated Verticals

B1. Healthcare Administration

What is happening:

- **Federal rules now put deadlines and public reporting on prior authorization, so slow manual review becomes a visible cost for health plans.** A CMS rule requires most affected payers to decide within 72 hours for urgent requests and seven calendar days for standard ones from January 1, 2026 (CMS), and practices complete 39 prior authorization requests per physician per week (AMA).
- **On the provider side the dominant health record vendor controls which AI tools run inside big health systems, according to a revenue cycle executive.** The executive says the vendor does not allow outside AI integrations beyond its own work (expert call).
- **Both labs launched healthcare products in January, and Anthropic's includes a sample template for the prior authorization review that health plans run today.** OpenAI launched ChatGPT for Healthcare on January 8 with HCA Healthcare, Cedars-Sinai and UCSF and templates that include prior authorization support (OpenAI), and three days later Claude for Healthcare added a CMS coverage connector and a customizable prior authorization review template (Anthropic).

Example companies: Anterior

B2. Insurance Operations

What is happening:

- **Insurers employ big claims and policy teams whose work follows forms, rules and deadlines that agents can follow too.** Government data counts 324,230 claims adjusters, examiners and investigators at a mean wage of $80,470 (BLS), and HFS expects traditional outsourcing to "decline from 55% to 37% of delivery" within two years (HFS Research).
- **Insurers are flooded with agent vendors and keep their data in their own systems.** An insurance executive says he is pitched two or three times a day, and adds that all of the data his team works with lives inside the insurer's existing systems (expert call).

- **The biggest carriers now get custom claims agents and agent platforms straight from the labs.** Allianz is co-developing motor and health claims agents with Anthropic (Allianz), State Farm was among the first adopters of OpenAI Frontier (OpenAI), and the listed insurtech Roadzen is launching underwriting and claims agents on Anthropic's managed agent platform (Roadzen filing).

Example companies: Notch, Pace, Harper, Strala

B3. Lending and Financial Crime

What is happening:

- **Financial crime compliance is a big and rising cost whose biggest line is people.** It costs institutions in the US and Canada $61 billion a year, and labor is the biggest cost within that spending (LexisNexis and Forrester).
- **The biggest banks build their own agents or buy packages straight from the labs.** Capital One built its own agent platform under model risk rules (podcast), and OpenAI built ChatGPT for Financial Services with Morgan Stanley and Evercore (OpenAI).
- **Anthropic and OpenAI now reach the rest of the banks through the core banking providers.** FIS made its AML agent, built with an embedded Anthropic team, available to any US bank in October (FIS), Fiserv launched agentOS with OpenAI as a collaborator and an AML triage agent among its four launch agents (Fiserv), and Anthropic's templates include KYC screening (Anthropic).
- **These bank agents recommend and leave each case with the bank's own staff.** The design partner for the FIS agent says "the investigator remains accountable for the final determination" (FIS).

Example companies: Salient, Bretton AI, Gradient Labs

B4. Legal Services

What is happening:

- **Legal work is a big services budget that buyers already pay per matter or per hour to outside firms.** Speakers at a Sequoia event put legal services alone at about $400B in the US (Sequoia event transcript).
- **Anthropic now sells a full legal product and says legal professionals became the most engaged users of its Cowork agent of any knowledge-work function.** Claude for Legal launched in May with 12 practice-area plugins and more than 20 connectors (Anthropic), and by October Anthropic had added more than 60 legal connectors and a gallery of legal tools built with law firms and PwC (Anthropic).
- **OpenAI followed in September with a legal configuration of its newest model, and its engineers now build custom tools inside several of the biggest law firms.** Astra for Law ships with a legal search index and 26 partner plugins, and OpenAI's forward-deployed engineers built tools for Sullivan & Cromwell, Ropes & Gray and Cooley (OpenAI).
- **Thomson Reuters rebuilt its CoCounsel product on Anthropic's agent toolkit and also launched a legal model of its own, so the research incumbent now competes on both the lab layer and the product.** It rebuilt CoCounsel on the Claude Agent SDK (Anthropic), and in August it launched Thomson 1.0, a model trained on its legal research content, while Google expanded Gemini Enterprise for legal professionals (Reuters).

Example companies: Crosby, Lawhive, EvenUp

B5. Life Sciences Research

What is happening:

- **Drug research is one of the biggest professional budgets in any industry and keeps growing.** R&D spending at the biggest pharma companies rose to $190Bn in 2024 from $163Bn in 2023 (IQVIA Institute).
- **Anthropic sells research products straight to drug companies, and research software stocks fell on the day it launched its research workbench.** Anthropic named Novo Nordisk and Sanofi as customers in

January (Anthropic), and Schrodinger shares fell as much as 8.3% the day Anthropic launched Claude Science in June, with Recursion and IQVIA also lower (trade press).

- **OpenAI has its own life sciences model and sells it to the same drug companies.** OpenAI launched a life sciences model with Amgen and Moderna in April (OpenAI), and its life sciences plugin connects more than 50 research tools (OpenAI).

Example companies: Edison Scientific

C. Non-Regulated Verticals

C1. Procurement, Logistics and Distribution

What is happening:

- **Purchasing and freight coordination employ big teams whose work runs on email, portals and phone calls.** Government data counts 491,430 buyers and purchasing agents, 202,810 dispatchers outside emergency services and 97,670 cargo and freight agents (BLS).
- **ERP suites now ship agents of their own that act inside the purchasing processes they already run.** Oracle launched 22 Fusion Agentic Applications that act inside its business processes (Oracle).
- **OpenAI is building and testing procurement agents that handle purchasing requests inside a single company, starting with its own finance team.** OpenAI is building a procurement agent with PwC inside its own finance team (OpenAI) and previewed specialist agents tested on procurement and invoice processing in September (OpenAI).

Example companies: Fragment, Magentic, Didero, InstaLILY, BackOps, HappyRobot, Freehand

C2. Finance and Accounting Operations

What is happening:

- **Finance teams repeat the same work every month with big clerical staffs, and every invoice or reconciliation has a clear count and cost.** Government data counts 1,373,680 bookkeeping, accounting and auditing clerks at a mean wage of $53,560 (BLS).
- **Agents cost more to run than the scripted bots finance teams already use, which slows the switch.** An integrator's automation lead says a task costing $200 or $300 a month on bots costs $1,000 or $1,200 a month with AI (expert call).
- **Both labs now go after the in-house monthly close directly, with templates and consulting partners.** Anthropic's spring financial services release includes a month-end closer (Anthropic), and OpenAI and PwC are building agents for planning, payments, tax and the accounting close (OpenAI).

Example companies: Basis, Niural

C3. Customer Service and Sales

What is happening:

- **Customer service is the first job agents finish end to end at scale, because a resolved ticket is easy to check and to price.** OpenAI says its Presence agent resolves 75% of inbound issues on its own phone line without human assistance, and it launched Presence in July as a deployed product for production support agents (OpenAI).
- **The big software suites now sell finished service work at a published price.** Salesforce charges $2 per resolution for its help agent and says its agents have handled 4.3 million inquiries on its own help site (CX Today), and Microsoft launched Contact Center Intelligence in October on top of existing systems from Cisco and Avaya (Constellation).
- **At least one big European telecom keeps the labs out of its contact center and plans to consolidate the specialist vendors it uses.** A Deutsche Telekom executive who deploys AI customer support says OpenAI

and Anthropic are rather no-goes for the company, and he plans to cut to one or two vendors within 18 months (expert call).

Example companies: Sierra, Decagon